and the number of Chinese reportedly killed defies any sort of mathematical sense. If we were to go by the projected claims, there would have been hardly any Chinese troops left in the Western Sector.

If awards in the Western Sector were handed out at random, the situation in NEFA was worse. Some MVCs and VrCs were given to individuals who were only interested in self-preservation, while those who had fought and died, especially at Nam Ka Chu and later at Walong, were ignored.

THE SMELL OF DEATH

One of the greatest tragedies of the clash with China in 1962 was India's failure to counter Chinese propaganda.

By 19 November, having ensured that there were no Indian formations left in the Bomdila region that could possibly allow the Indians to counter-attack and re-establish a foothold in the Kameng Frontier Division, the Chinese changed tack. They were fully aware that all the committed Indian formations in NEFA had ceased to exist as cohesive bodies. Having thus achieved their immediate objective, Chou En-lai had called the Indian Charge d'Affaires in Peking and told him that China was declaring an immediate ceasefire from midnight the next day. Owing to the complex cipher procedures—and what must rank as one of the most inexplicable and absurd delays of all times—this information was not transmitted to the Indian government in time, leaving them to learn of the Chinese announcement from the newspapers almost forty hours later.

With only stragglers left in the Kameng Frontier Division, the Chinese field commanders gave specific orders to stop taking prisoners and maximize Indian casualties. The aim obviously was to terrorize the rest of India and brand Chinese supremacy on the Indian psyche for years to come. According to Major Sitaram Johri, who had been the political officer in Bomdila, after the ceasefire 'they ruthlessly indulged in the slaughter of Indians. It is worth noting that the number of Indian casualties after the ceasefire was far more than before it. On the other hand the number of POWs was greater before the ceasefire than after it. Thus the Chinese accomplished their aim.'

Having annihilated the surviving Indian troops (the only organized resistance being put up by Lieutenant Colonel Avasthy's 4 Rajput column at the Lagyala Gompa, where again there were no prisoners taken or any